I: SOMALIA AND THE UNION OF ISLAMIC COURTS

In 2006, when this document was leaked, the Union of Islamic Courts was the dominant political force in Somalia. The Union evolved out of the local courts that developed to administer Sharia law in the 1990s. These courts, each of which was supported by its own militia, formed a loose alliance in early 2006 and began to take control of much of the country, including the capital Mogadishu. Given that Somalia had been without an effective government since 1991, the rise of the Union seemed to be an interesting development. This secret order, purportedly written by the most important man in the Union, Sheik Aweys, came to WikiLeaks from a Chinese source who had received it from the UN-sponsored Transitional Federal Government of Somalia, who are effectively the Union's opposition. When releasing the document on 28 December 2006, WikiLeaks drew attention to their doubts about its provenance and authenticity. The Union has since been broken up and many of its leaders exiled after an invasion by Ethiopian troops that took place around the time of this leak.